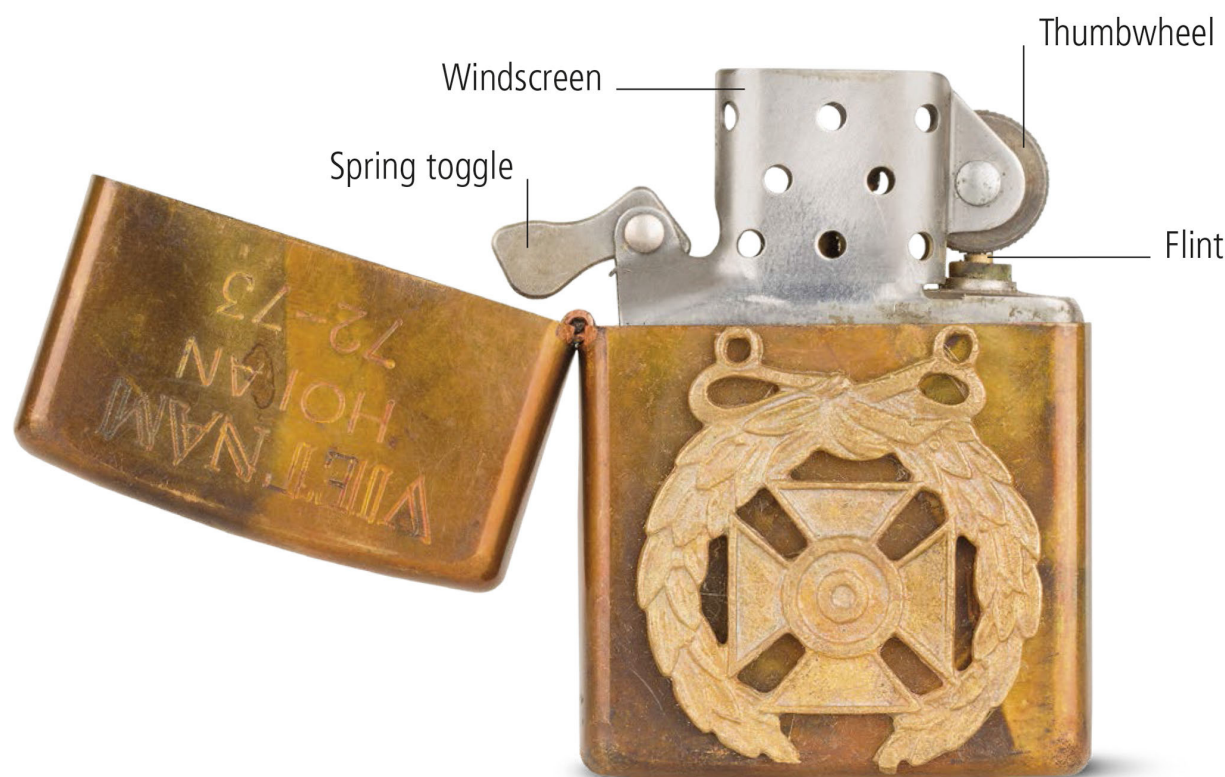


An archipelago of fire support bases built throughout South Vietnam provided security to US military installations and delivered devastating firepower to search-and-destroy missions. Such firebases could be fairly elaborate and semipermanent, or could be more rudimentary, built and dismantled as the company moved on. Either way, they would always have a landing zone (LZ) for helicopters, medical and communication areas, and a tactical operations center. Soldiers would hunker down in hootches (improvised shelters) or dugouts fortified with sandbags.

“[I]t wasn’t nothing unusual about **burning them hootches down ...** It’s just a normal procedure we do.”

VETERAN JACK HILL, RECALLING A SEARCH-AND-DESTROY OPERATION IN 1967



Fire power

Soldiers on search-and-destroy missions used their lighters to set fire to property. This lighter has an Army marksmanship qualification badge welded onto the front.

Measuring success

Military Assistance Command Vietnam (MACV) evaluated search-and-destroy operations by the statistical analysis of data—pounds of rice seized, the quantity of weapons captured, and the number of combatants killed. The body count became search-and-destroy’s main measure of success, with combat units rewarded by commendations, bragging rights, and even prizes such as “stand-down R&R”—a period spent in a base with superior amenities.